



NESLOKE-*Lite*

Game Master's Guide

Running the game, building encounters, and the Giljair mini-campaign

by KevTyler

PART 1: THE NECESSARY MECHANICS

The mechanics a Game Master needs at the table: the combat quick-reference, running enemies, and the hazard system.



1. THE COMBAT QUICK-REFERENCE

The single surface the GM keeps open to resolve any attack. No stat block ever restates these rules; they live here once. This card is combat-only by design.

THE ROLL

1d12 + Attribute + Tokens (max 3, +1 each) vs. DA.

HIT SEVERITY

MARGIN OVER DA	RESULT	EFFECT
-2 to -1	Partial Hit	-1 FP target, -1 FP attacker
0 to +1	Grazing Hit	-2 FP target
+2 to +5	Direct Hit	-4 FP target
+6 or more	Critical Hit	-6 FP and -1 WP target

A margin of exactly +5 is a Direct Hit. A Critical Hit begins at +6 over DA, not before.

AT 0 FP

Further FP damage overflows into WP. If a character is already at 0 FP when a hit lands, that hit deals a minimum of 1 WP, plus 1 more WP per full 5 points of its damage. If a hit drives a character to 0 FP, only the damage past 0 counts as overflow: 1 WP per full 5 points of that overflow, no minimum. A Critical Hit always deals its own 1 WP on top. The character gains 1 Strain per turn spent at 0 FP (max -6). Death is at 0 WP.

DA SCALE (FOR IMPROVISED CHECKS)

Trivial 4 to 6 · Challenging 7 to 10 · Demanding 11 to 13 · Heroic 14 to 16 · Legendary 17+.

EDGE AND STRAIN

Edge +2, does not stack. Strain -2 per stack, up to 3 stacks (max -6).

TOKENS

Boost a roll (1 to 3, +1 each) or pay a skill cost. No auto-success.

ACTIONS PER TURN

1 Core, 1 Minor, 2 Reactions, Incidentals as reasonable. Group turn, no individual initiative.



2. ENEMIES AT THE TABLE

This is the combat-time reference for reading and running an enemy. The full ladder, the ready templates, and the method for building your own live in Part 2, Section 4; this section is only what you need with a fight already underway.

Enemies are bodies, run identically to players: FP first, then WP, death at 0 WP, standard overflow and crit rules, with certain abilities striking WP directly. Each enemy has one DA; the enemy rolls to attack and the player's DA defends. There are no contested rolls and no forced defensive rolls. Every attack's modifier is baked into its line, so you look at the attack and roll.

Enemies do not use Tokens. Where an ability needs a limit, it carries a fixed number of uses, or it is unlimited, or it is passive. Nothing on an enemy asks you to track a pool.

READING A STAT BLOCK

A block lists, in order: Name and Tier, then DA (with its source attribute), FP, and WP; then Attacks, each as Name (Action type): 1d12 + modifier vs. target DA; then Abilities written function-first like player skills (Action type, use count, then effect); then optional Notes on morale or tactics. Tier is a tuning label, not a mechanic.

GARRISON GUARD, FODDER

DA 8 (END) • FP 4 • WP 2

Spear (Core): 1d12 +2 vs. target DA.

Notes: fights in numbers; breaks and flees when clearly outmatched.

ROYAL GUARD CAPTAIN, ELITE

DA 10 (STR) • FP 12 • WP 6

Warblade (Core): 1d12 +4 vs. target DA.

Shield Wall (Reaction, 2 uses): an adjacent ally gains +2 DA against one incoming attack.

Hold the Line (Minor, unlimited): until the Captain's next turn, allies who can see it gain +1 to attack rolls.

Notes: rarely fights to the death; will parley or withdraw once its guards fall.

WHEN ENEMIES FLEE OR SURRENDER

Enemies break, run, surrender, and negotiate; not every fight is to the death. Part 2, Section 4 covers reading morale and letting a rout or surrender change the scene.

3. THE HAZARD SYSTEM

Hazards cover damage from the environment and from serious threats: falls, fire, gas, explosions, collapsing ground, and the like. They resolve on their own d12 tables rather than through the attack engine.

VOCABULARY

Hazard Levels (1 to 4) are the kind of hazard: Potential, Serious, Dire, Lethal. Damage Tiers are the four severity bands within each level's d12 table.

THE DAMAGE ROLL

The GM rolls 1d12 on the hazard's table. There is no miss; the band the roll falls in determines the damage.

THE REACTION

When the fiction gives the character a moment and a means to respond, they may attempt a reaction roll: 1d12 + the relevant attribute vs. the Hazard Level's DA.

Reaction DA by Hazard Level: Level 1 = 9, Level 2 = 10, Level 3 = 11, Level 4 = 12.

REACTION RESULT	MARGIN VS. DA	EFFECT
Critical success	+6 or more	Step down two Damage Tiers
General success	meet DA to +5	Step down one Damage Tier
Partial	1 to 2 below DA	Step down one Damage Tier, and take +1 FP
Failure	3 to 7 below DA	Full damage, +2 FP
Critical failure	8 or more below DA	Full damage, +4 FP

Band one is the floor. A step-down never goes below it. A character may decline to react, and there is no benefit to reacting against a band-one result (a partial would only cost FP for nothing gained).

The reaction is a normal typed roll. The relevant attribute adds as it would on any roll of that type, and Unarmored's +1 to DEX rolls applies when the hazard calls for a DEX reaction.

THE DAMAGE TABLES

LEVEL 1, POTENTIAL

D12	DAMAGE
1 to 5	none
6 to 8	-2 FP
9 to 10	-4 FP
11 to 12	-1 WP

LEVEL 2, SERIOUS

D12	DAMAGE
1 to 4	-2 FP
5 to 8	-4 FP
9 to 11	-1 WP and -3 FP
12	-2 WP and -4 FP

LEVEL 3, DIRE

D12	DAMAGE
1 to 4	-5 FP
5 to 8	-1 WP and -3 FP
9 to 11	-2 WP and -5 FP
12	-3 WP and -6 FP

LEVEL 4, LETHAL

D12	DAMAGE
1 to 2	-3 WP and -3 FP
3 to 7	-4 WP and -6 FP
8 to 11	-6 WP and -8 FP
12	-8 WP and -10 FP

REACTABLE VERSUS UNAVOIDABLE

Whether a hazard can be reacted to is a GM judgment. A hazard is reactable when the fiction gives the character a moment and a means to respond. It is unavoidable when it does not. The test is agency at the moment of impact, not how dangerous the hazard is. Unavoidable hazards should be rare and should almost never sit at Dire or Lethal. When a hazard offers no reaction, that is a signal to lower the Hazard Level, not raise it. Removing the reaction and rolling the deadliest table at once is a double punishment.

THE LETHAL CONSTRAINT

Lethal hazards must be telegraphed. If a player could not have seen it coming, do not roll on the Lethal table. Lethal is never forced on players who are making good decisions; it is only ever the consequence of ignoring reasonable warning. In practice Lethal should not appear before level 3, and even then it should be rare, never routine. The reaction always mitigates but never erases; even the best case on the Lethal table still costs a wound.

PART 2: RUNNING NESLOKE

How to run Nesloke: adjudicating checks, pacing rest, building encounters, and advancing characters. The connective tissue between the combat card in Part 1 and the campaign in Part 3.

1. THE GM'S JOB

You set the scene, the players tell you what they attempt, and you decide what happens. Most of that resolves in conversation. A roll enters only when the outcome is genuinely uncertain and the result matters. When you do call for one, you name the attribute, set a DA, and narrate the outcome by its tier. That is the whole loop, and it repeats through exploration, conversation, and combat.

Two habits carry the rest of this Part. First, ask for a roll only when both a success and a failure would be interesting; if failure just stalls the story, let the players succeed and move on. Second, keep your attention on the fiction and the encounter, not on bookkeeping. Nesloke deliberately keeps the GM's tracking light so you can stay present at the table.

WHAT YOU TRACK, AND WHAT YOU DO NOT

You track the bodies in a fight: FP, WP, and DA for each enemy. You do not track a token pool for any NPC. Tokens are a player-side resource, part of how the players manage scarcity turn to turn, and that management is their game to play. Putting a matching pool on every enemy would be pure overhead with no payoff, since an enemy exists to pressure the party, not to run its own optimization. Where an enemy ability

needs a limiter, it carries a flat number of uses. That is the full extent of enemy resource tracking. Section 4 covers this in detail.

N 2. ADJUDICATING CHECKS

WHEN TO ROLL

Roll when the outcome is uncertain and both results are interesting. Do not roll to open an unlocked door, to recall something a character would obviously know, or to succeed at something the fiction has already earned. A roll is a spotlight; point it only where the story bends on the result.

CHOOSING THE ATTRIBUTE

Pick the attribute that matches the action, not the goal. Forcing a stuck window is END or STR; spotting the ambush that made the window matter is a perception read; talking the guard into opening it is a social attribute. The same objective can call for different attributes depending on how a player approaches it, and honoring that is what makes attributes feel meaningful. Let the player's described method choose the stat.

SETTING THE DA

Read the DA straight off the improvised scale from Part 1:

Trivial 4 to 6, Challenging 7 to 10, Demanding 11 to 13, Heroic 14 to 16, Legendary 17 or more.

Set the number before the player rolls, from the fiction alone, and do not move it to engineer a result. A locked DA the players can feel is fairer and more legible than one that drifts to fit your intention. If circumstances clearly help or hinder, apply Edge or Strain rather than nudging the DA: Edge is +2 and does not stack; Strain is -2 per stack up to three stacks.

READING THE OUTCOME

The margin over or under DA tells you how the attempt lands. A clean success carries the action. A narrow miss should still move the story, changing cost, position, time, resources, or the quality of what was learned rather than dead-ending it. Section 6 covers failure in full. The point here is that most checks have more than two outcomes, and narrating the shade between them is where the system comes alive.

GROUP AND COOPERATIVE CHECKS

When the whole party faces one obstacle together, you have two clean tools. A cooperative check lets one character lead while others who can meaningfully help grant Edge to the leader's roll rather than each rolling separately. A group check, used when every character must clear the same bar, succeeds when at least half the party succeeds. Reach for cooperative when one person acts with support, and group when the situation tests everyone at once, such as a whole party crossing bad ground.

WHEN NOT TO CALL FOR A ROLL AT ALL

Some things should simply happen. If a player has set up a clever plan, gathered the right leverage, and there is no real chance of failure, reward that with a yes rather than a die. Dice are for uncertainty, and spending them on foregone conclusions teaches players that preparation does not matter. Protect the value of the roll by using it sparingly.

3. REST AND RECOVERY

Characters recover through rest. These are the authoritative values; the Player's Guide summarizes them and points here for the full picture, and the Part 3 campaign leans on them directly.

REST TYPE	DURATION	FP	WP AND WOUNDS
Short Rest	2 in-game hours	Half FP restored	No WP by default; no wound healing
Long Rest	8 in-game hours	Full FP	Up to half WP; minor wounds healed
Unsafe Rest	Varies	Normal, or halved if an encounter occurs	Same, or none if interrupted

A Short Rest also restores 2 Tokens to each character, not half the pool. A Long Rest restores each character's Tokens to full. WP recovery on a Short Rest is not a default; it happens only when a specific skill or attribute permits it. An Unsafe Rest recovers as normal unless an encounter actually interrupts it, in which case all recovery is halved.

PACING REST AS A DESIGN LEVER

Rest is your primary pacing dial, and where you place a rest opportunity shapes the tension of everything after it. A clear Long Rest before a fight lets the party enter fresh, which suits a teaching encounter. Withholding rest across a stretch of play turns a sequence into an attrition problem, where each Token and each point of FP spent early is felt later. Both are valid; choose deliberately. Signal a safe rest when you want the party refreshed, and let the absence of one be a real pressure when you want the session to bite. Telling players plainly whether a moment is safe to rest is good practice, not a giveaway.

4. ENEMIES AND THE NPC LADDER

Enemies run on the same rules as players: FP first, then WP, death at 0 WP, standard overflow and crit rules from Part 1, with certain abilities striking WP directly. Each enemy has one DA; the enemy rolls to attack

and the player's DA defends. There are no contested rolls and no forced defensive rolls. Every attack's modifier is baked into its line, so you look at the attack and roll.

Enemies do not use Tokens. Where an ability needs a limit, it has a fixed number of uses, or it is unlimited, or it is passive. Nothing on an enemy asks you to manage a pool.

THE STAT-BLOCK FORMAT

Fields, in order:

- ◆ Name and Tier (Basic, Fodder, Standard, Elite; tier is a tuning label, not a mechanic)
- ◆ DA and its source attribute, so you can retune
- ◆ FP and WP
- ◆ Attacks, each as: Name (Action type): 1d12 + modifier vs. target DA. One line of what is distinctive, if anything.
- ◆ Abilities, function-first, written exactly like player skills: Action type, use count, then what it does
- ◆ Notes (optional): morale, tactics, tendency to flee or surrender. Narrative, never a forced roll.

THE UNIFIED LADDER

Four rungs cover almost everything. The numbers are the stripped floor; you build up from them by adding capability back as deliberate choices.

TIER	DA	FP	WP	READS AS
Basic	6	3	1	an ordinary person: innkeeper, merchant, frightened villager
Fodder	8	4	2	trained but weak alone: guard, bandit, conscript
Standard	9	7	3	a Level 1 character's fighting presence
Elite	10	12	6	a Level 3 character's fighting presence

A Basic body is trivially hit and folds almost instantly if violence finds it; it attacks, if at all, with an improvised 1d12 +0. A Fodder body has one trained attack, roughly 1d12 +2, and fights in numbers. A Standard body has a solid attack, roughly 1d12 +3 or +4, and reads as the threat a starting player character

projects, without the player's skills. An Elite body is the mid-fight wall and reads as a Level 3 character's physical presence, again without player skills or special attacks.

Note that a tier describes combat presence, not survivability point-for-point against a real player character. A player character of the matching level also has skills, which the stat block does not carry, so a tier-matched body is a fair pressure on the party rather than a mirror duel.

EXAMPLE: FODDER BODY

GARRISON GUARD, FODDER

DA 8 (END) • FP 4 • WP 2

Spear (Core): 1d12 +2 vs. target DA.

Notes: fights in numbers; breaks and flees when clearly outmatched.

EXAMPLE: ELITE BODY

ROYAL GUARD CAPTAIN, ELITE

DA 10 (STR) • FP 12 • WP 6

Warblade (Core): 1d12 +4 vs. target DA.

Shield Wall (Reaction, 2 uses): an adjacent ally gains +2 DA against one incoming attack.

Hold the Line (Minor, unlimited): until the Captain's next turn, allies who can see it gain +1 to attack rolls.

Notes: rarely fights to the death; will parley or withdraw once its guards fall.

(Example numbers follow the ladder; scale bodies and counts to your party, not the DA or attack bonus.)

BUILDING YOUR OWN

Start from the tier floor and add back only what the concept needs.

- ◆ Attributes: add attribute bonuses to fit the concept. DA equals 6 plus the defensive attribute, so a tougher body's DA rises naturally from that choice.
- ◆ Attacks: set each attack's baked-in modifier from the concept, so the line is a look-and-roll.
- ◆ FP and WP: pick durability from the tier logic above. WP is the tension dial; keep it modest.
- ◆ Abilities: bolt on a signature trick, written function-first like a player skill, gated by a use count if it needs a limit.

To signal a real threat, lean on a higher DA, a sharper baked attack modifier, more bodies, and one memorable ability, not on inflated raw numbers.

WHEN ENEMIES FLEE OR SURRENDER

Not every fight is to the death. Enemies break, run, surrender, and negotiate. Read when an enemy would realistically give up, signal it to the players, and let a rout or a surrender change the scene. Letting enemies flee is good pacing, not a loss of tension. If a morale prompt helps, reach for one, for instance when a leader falls or a group hits half strength, and consider whether they hold. It is a tool you may offer, never a forced roll.

5. BUILDING ENCOUNTERS

SCALE BY BODIES, NOT BY NUMBERS

The honest way to make a fight harder is to add bodies, better organization, blocked routes, and worsening circumstances, not to secretly inflate DA or attack bonuses behind the screen. Players can feel an encounter that fights fair and lose faith in one that does not. Set your tier and your counts from the fiction, then let attrition and position do the work of difficulty.

A rough starting frame: roughly one body per player for a standard fight, weighted by tier for the pressure you want. A simple introductory fight might be one Fodder or Standard body per player with a clear way for the party to win. A harder set piece raises the tier, adds numbers, and takes away easy exits and easy rests.

ATTRITION AS THE REAL DIFFICULTY

Difficulty in Nesloke rises most through attrition. A single dangerous fight after a full rest is less threatening than a chain of modest fights with no rest between them, because the second drains FP, Tokens, and WP with no chance to recover. When you want a session to feel dangerous, control the rest, not the enemy math. A party running on one resource pool across a whole sequence feels the stakes without any hidden inflation.

WHAT A BODY CANNOT DO

A stat block is pressure, not a plot. Enemies change the situation the players are in; they do not resolve the players' decisions for them. Keep the encounter's job clear: it tests the party's resources and choices, and the players decide how it ends.

N 6. FAILURE, CONSEQUENCE, AND THE FIGHT THAT IS NOT REQUIRED

FAIL FORWARD

A failed check should change the situation, not end the story. Let a miss cost the party position, time, resources, or the quality of what they learn, and keep the path open. Important information in particular should belong to a scene and to the world, not to a single check or a single NPC, so that one bad roll never locks the party out of what they need to proceed. A dead end is almost always a sign that too much was riding on one die.

NOT EVERYTHING IS RESOLVED BY FIGHTING

Build real alternatives to violence where they make sense, and be honest when they do not. The goal is not to contrive three solutions into every scene; sometimes a fight genuinely is the only way through, and pretending otherwise is its own kind of dishonesty. What you owe the players is that when an alternative exists in the fiction, it actually works: a surrender that is accepted, a negotiation that can succeed, a route that can be found. Combat does not have to begin or end with violence. Surrender, negotiation, retreat, interruption, and a change of sides are all legitimate outcomes, and reading for them is a core GM skill.

LET ACCOMPLISHMENT BE REAL

When the players achieve what they set out to do, let it land. Do not walk back a hard-won outcome to preserve a planned finale or to keep a threat alive past its moment. The reward for good play is that it changed what happened, and honoring that is what makes the next hard choice matter.

N 7. ADVANCEMENT

Characters in Nesloke Lite grow from Level 1 to Level 3, the opening stretch of a longer climb that reaches Level 12 in the full game. Advancement is by Milestone, the story-driven method the campaign in Part 3 uses.

MILESTONE LEVELING

Milestone progression is the method the campaign in Part 3 uses. The group levels when a major story arc concludes or a significant turning point occurs. It removes tracking while preserving pacing, which suits story-driven play. As GM, you decide when a milestone has been reached and level the whole party together.

THE LEVELING PROCEDURE

When a character gains a level, apply these in order.

1. **Skill Points.** Skill Points buy new skills from the character's tree and are permanent once spent. A character has 3 SP at Level 1, gains 2 more at Level 2 (5 total), and 2 more at Level 3 (7 total). Skill costs rise with power: Level 1 and Level 2 skills cost 1 SP each, and Level 3 skills cost 2 SP, so the Level 3 gain buys one skill. SP is spent only during downtime or level-up, never mid-encounter, and never mixes with Tokens.
2. **FP and WP Growth.** Follow each archetype's own growth curve on the character sheet; the curves are authored per archetype and are not uniform. In general FP climbs each level while WP climbs more slowly, WP first rising at Level 3.
3. **Token Growth.** Maximum Token pool grows by +2 per level for every archetype, with no exceptions. A character starts with a maximum of 12 and reaches a maximum of 16 by Level 3.

Part 2 ends here. Part 1 holds the combat card, the enemy rules in brief, and the hazard system; Part 3 is the Giljair mini-campaign. The enemy material in Part 1 has been brought into line with the token-free ladder above and should be read together with Section 4.

PART 3: THE GILJAIR MINI-CAMPAIGN

A complete Level 1 to 3 adventure: campaign structure, storyworld, scenes, Giljair Keep, the NPC roster, combat references, and GM teaching tools.

CONTENTS

1. Campaign Purpose and Teaching Arc
2. Giljair Storyworld Foundations
3. Campaign Spine and Central Conspiracy
4. Session 1 - Learn
5. Session 2 - Manage
6. Session 3 - Endure / Decide
7. Giljair Keep - Entry and Theater-of-the-Mind Structure
8. Giljair Keep - Four Major Areas
9. Running the Sundown Invasion
10. NPC Roster
11. Unique NPC Combat Profiles
12. Using Allies and Powerful NPCs
13. Objective Resolution and Aftermath

14. GM Running Principles and Flexible Elements

Appendix A. Technology Reference

Appendix B. Locked Names and Naming Style



1. CAMPAIGN PURPOSE AND TEACHING ARC

The Giljair mini-campaign is the complete Level 1-3 adventure included in Neslake Lite. It is designed to teach both players and a new GM through play. Each session has a different mechanical and GM-facing purpose, while the campaign remains Storyworld-first and specifically rooted in Giljair.

SESSION	LEVEL / RESOURCE STATE	PRIMARY PLAYER LESSON	PRIMARY STORY JOB
Session 1 - Learn	Level 1; obvious Long Rest before first battle	Use checks, skills, Tokens, Edge, Strain, outcomes, roleplay, and first combat. Spend liberally and learn what resources do.	Begin with ordinary Giljair, reveal an apparent Shanderonian attack, rescue/pursuit, and end with a larger threat involving Giljair Keep.
Session 2 - Manage	Begins depleted at Level 1; Level 2 refresh midway	Move from "Can I spend this?" to "Should I spend this?" Manage Tokens, FP, time, and choices.	Continue the pursuit, reveal the attackers as mercenaries, and connect the operation to Annethil.
Session 3 - Endure / Decide	Begins fully rested at Level 3; no Short or Long Rest for the entire session	Everything draws from one resource pool. Decide what is worth spending, when to avoid fights, and how to survive attrition.	Discover the coup, enter Giljair Keep, choose an objective, shape the invasion, accomplish what matters, and escape.

SESSION 1 - LEARN

Level 1. Use lots of checks and opportunities to spend Tokens and use skills.

Encourage experimentation and spending rather than hoarding.

A clear, obvious Long Rest appears before the first battle so the party enters combat refreshed.

The first fight is simple and is not intended to kill the PCs. Enemies care about escaping and completing their mission.

The Level 2 milestone is deliberately delayed into Session 2 so the Session 1 battle matters to the next session.

Giljair should be shown as a real nation with good and bad people, not as an inherently evil state.

SESSION 2 - MANAGE

Begins immediately after Session 1 with no rest.

The first half forces depleted Level 1 characters to choose whether a Token or other resource is worth spending.

A town in the middle provides a natural rest opportunity and the Level 2 milestone. If the PCs refuse to rest, they still level and refresh as though rested.

The second half gives fresh Level 2 characters a chance to use new tools, then tests them in a harder fight.

The final enemies are approximately Level 3-equivalent, and roughly half are Potezen.

The session ends by proving that Annethil is connected to the attacks.

SESSION 3 - ENDURE / DECIDE

Between Sessions 2 and 3, advance the PCs to Level 3 and refresh them fully. This is their last refresh of the campaign.

No Short Rest or Long Rest is available anywhere in Session 3, including before sundown at Giljair Keep.

The first half is roleplay, discovery, entry, and preparation; all of it can still cost resources.

The final Keep sequence is an attrition battle. Combat is dangerous but not mandatory.

The players define their objective. They may help Annethil, stop Annethil, save or kill the Lead Superior, capture someone, expose the conspiracy, rob the Keep, free prisoners, or create a different goal.

The campaign allows real death, failure, and consequences in Session 3.



2. GILJAIR STORYWORLD FOUNDATIONS

GILJAIR AMONG THE SIX NATIONS

NATION / REGION	RELATIONSHIP TO GILJAIR
Penora	Directly north. Uneasy peace. Penora has the second-largest navy after Nylorac.
Bastrone	Southeast, separated largely by mountains and forest. Giljair has attempted territorial expansion, but Bastrone's strong mountain army has repeatedly stopped it. No active formal peace, but Giljair has lost too much fighting them.
Shanderon	East. Active war with Giljair for more than 100 years. Deep mutual hatred; the border moves as advantages change.
Shilmeer	Giljair's ally. Smaller population, much open land, self-sufficient. Alliance is primarily defensive and convenient; Shilmeer does not actively join Giljair's wars.
Nylorac	Strongest nation, most magically-technologically advanced, largest navy, and at peace with all because attacking it would be irrational.
Desert of Lost Souls	Dangerous, unclaimed land east of Giljair that is difficult to cross.

Giljair has a reputation among other nations as an instigator or bad actor. Historically, that reputation is sometimes deserved and sometimes not.

GOVERNMENT AND POWER

Giljair is an oligarchy ruled by the Nine Families of Power.

Each Family has one vote on national matters.

Leadership cycles in a nine-year sequence. One Family serves as Head of the Nine for a year, and that year is named for the Family (for example, the Year of Annethil).

The Head breaks tied votes and serves as Peasant Judge, able to issue judgment on disputes brought to the kingdom/government without consulting the others.

Each of the Nine controls a section/territory of Giljair.

The Nine collectively select the general who leads Giljair's military: the Lead Superior.

Many people claim the Lead Superior is the person who actually rules Giljair because practical military power can exceed political authority.

House Ilmarinen is wealthy but is not one of the Nine.

The campaign takes place in the Year of Annethil.

THE NINE FAMILIES OF POWER

FAMILY	CURRENT CAMPAIGN RELEVANCE
Annethil	Current Head of the Nine. Behind the coup against the Lead Superior.
Sharbeerd	One of the Nine. No further House identity is required for this mini-campaign.
Bagimoos	One of the Nine. Lead Superior Hiff Bagimoos is a member of this House.
Greval	Named; no additional House identity is required for this mini-campaign.
Newcera	Named; no additional House identity is required for this mini-campaign.
Forjinks	Named; no additional House identity is required for this mini-campaign.
Stealelle	Named; no additional House identity is required for this mini-campaign.
Midclow	Named; no additional House identity is required for this mini-campaign.
Elsver	Named; no additional House identity is required for this mini-campaign.

SOCIETY SHAPED BY WAR

The currency across Nesloke, Giljair included, is Geld.

Men have mandatory military service at age 24. Exemptions are limited to genuine illness, injury, or disability; there are no broad religious or similar exemptions.

Women have a mandatory obligation at age 24 and may: serve and fight; serve in non-fighting military roles; have a husband serving and raise potential children; pay their way out; or contract ten years of indentured servitude to one of the Nine Families.

Known Potezen, male or female, are treated differently and are forced into the army at age 20.

Giljair has dangerous border settlements and a culture deeply shaped by the century-long war.

Privatized news is allowed and publications can criticize the state, but there is no protected freedom of speech. A critic's safety often comes from popularity and the government's fear of unrest rather than legal protection.

Families and civilians are intentionally protected where possible. Women and children are prioritized in evacuations; women serving in the military are an exception to front-line restrictions.

Children often experience the war through missing or dead relatives rather than direct front-line exposure.

A common understanding is that only around seven in ten people entering the army survive long enough to unenlist.

MAJOR MILITARY BRANCHES

BRANCH	ROLE
Ranged Units	Elite ranger units, often including Hunters.
Guard Units	Protect ruling families.
Amphibious Units	Marine-like force working with Fleet Units and conducting ground assault.
Fleet Units	Navy.
Cavalry Units	Elite-ish mounted regular army; horses.
Infantry Units	Primary army.

POTEZEN IN GILJAIR

Across Nesloke, only about 1 in 500 people are born Potezen, and most never develop impressive powers.

In Giljair, weak Potezen are expected to prove that their weakness is genuine rather than a lack of effort.

Known Potezen are identified through rigorous testing and forced into military service at age 20.

Testing and training are often lethal because authorities push Potezen to demonstrate or increase their abilities.

This pressure encourages weak Potezen to hide their abilities.

Potezen power is coveted by the Nine Families because land and wealth cannot purchase innate power.

Across the Nine, only one or two Potezen may appear in an entire generation, and even they may be weak.

Giljair is not magically saturated. A local villager unexpectedly revealing telekinesis should still shock everyone around them.

Once exposed, a Potezen may enter the "small world" of Potezen who know or know of one another and sometimes protect each other, particularly under Giljair's pressure.

GEOGRAPHY AND TRAVEL FEEL

Southwestern Giljair is vibrant, wet, actively alive forest. Paths can be lost or overrun. The internal aesthetic reference is ancient Northern Florida without modern roads or cities.

Central Giljair contains fishing villages, towns, and cities along its primary river.

Giljair has a strong fishing culture and one of the more flexible navies, able to operate on rivers and larger water.

Distances between settlements and castles are large. Roads are not barren; the feeling is isolation rather than emptiness.

Wealth is concentrated around The Citadel and Giljair Keep, with many trade routes passing through them.

Giljair is not inherently poor, though poor cities exist.

Open-road travel away from the major castles is dangerous because of fear of Shanderonian ambushes.

TWO MAJOR CASTLES

LOCATION	PURPOSE
The Citadel	Western political seat where the Nine rule.
Giljair Keep	Eastern military castle that houses the Lead Superior and much of Giljair's army.



4. CAMPAIGN SPINE AND CENTRAL CONSPIRACY

STARTING PREMISE

The PCs meet independently in a small Giljairian river village, working name Cypress Bend. Dockmaster Jestine Lyn has rung the morning bell for breakfast and is serving food near the docks, naturally bringing the PCs and locals together. The PCs are not pre-selected heroes; they are simply capable people who happen to be present when a crisis arrives.

A damaged small Giljairian Navy river vessel drifts into view, riding low and taking on water. At first there is no visible movement aboard. It looks like a dead ship.

THE APPARENT ATTACK

The attackers are Shanderonian mercenaries hired by House Annethil. In Session 1, everyone - including the PCs - reasonably believes they were Shanderonian Army soldiers. Their speech, equipment, appearance, and

tactics are sufficiently Shanderonian to support that conclusion. Do not hint too early that they are mercenaries or that Annethil is involved.

ANNETHIL'S CONSPIRACY

Annethil is one of the Nine and serves as Head of the Nine during the Year of Annethil.

Concern about Hiff Bagimoos is not unique to Annethil. Leadership across the Nine has been watching his growing practical authority and the army's increasing personal loyalty to him.

The Nine share the problem, not the solution: only Annethil has chosen to resolve the concern through a conspiracy and armed assault.

Annethil believes the Lead Superior has become too powerful and that the Nine no longer possess enough real authority.

Annethil's ultimate objective is to kill Hiff Bagimoos and break/rebalance the military's current political power.

Annethil pays mercenaries of various sorts, including Shanderonians, to attack Giljair's Navy and other military assets.

These attacks are designed to deplete and disperse Giljair's military so Giljair Keep can be infiltrated and attacked.

Stolen Geld can help finance the operation, but the strategic goal is military depletion, not robbery.

Session 2 reveals Annethil's connection. Session 3 reveals the full purpose and lets the PCs decide what to do about it.

HIFF BAGIMOOS AND THE POLITICAL TENSION

Hiff Bagimoos did not set out to become more powerful than the Nine. His authority grew because the century-long war repeatedly produced situations where waiting for nine political families to debate meant soldiers died, territory was lost, or Shanderon gained ground. He increasingly makes military decisions because he refuses to let Giljair lose because of oligarchic paralysis.

Hiff does not necessarily believe he should rule Giljair. The danger is that his practical authority and the personal loyalty he commands within the military now exceed what the office was originally intended to hold. This makes Annethil's fear understandable without making Annethil's methods morally correct.

NO UNIVERSAL CORRECT ENDING The campaign does not tell the PCs that helping Annethil, protecting Hiff Bagimoos, stopping both, or exploiting the battle is the morally correct answer. The players decide what they want to accomplish. The GM responds to that objective and lets consequences follow.



5. SESSION 1 - LEARN

Session 1 teaches the core game through a complete miniature arc: ordinary morning -> catastrophe -> rescue and investigation -> pursuit -> obvious rest -> first combat -> larger threat.

SCENE 1 - RIVER VILLAGE BREAKFAST

Working village name: Cypress Bend.

Jestine Lyn, the dockmaster, is the primary local NPC. She has just rung a dock bell for breakfast and is serving food from the dockhouse/open-sided dock area.

The dock gathering is not necessarily an inn. Feeding people developed naturally because villagers and travelers already gathered at the docks.

The PCs arrive independently for reasons appropriate to their backgrounds and stories. Breakfast creates a natural introduction scene.

Use ordinary life to show Geld, fishing, Navy traffic, private newspapers, military-service discussion, and the normalization of war without a lore lecture.

The damaged Navy vessel rounds the bend and Jestine recognizes something is wrong.

SCENE 2 - THE DEAD / DAMAGED NAVY VESSEL

NPC	ROLE / SITUATION
Jan Ian Tor	Amphibious crewman. The only living military person. Hit multiple times and actively dying/barely alive; attackers thought he was dead.
Hiff Wester	Rug merchant. His rugs were destroyed/drowned when the vessel flooded. His business partner died. Two crates of Hiff's Geld were stolen.
Bell Rusk and Jraskor Rusk	Civilian couple traveling between towns to visit their children. Survived by hiding below deck.
Lantyre Blent	Crew Officer and highest officer aboard. Missing; taken alive. Crew Officers often lead around 19 Navy soldiers, though this was a smaller river Navy ship.

The mercenaries damaged the vessel in the initial fight. It did not travel far before taking on too much water and reached the village through proximity and luck.

Present the immediate problems as chaos, not a checklist. The PCs may secure the sinking vessel, board through corpses and signs of combat, notice Jan is still breathing, rescue hidden survivors threatened by

flooding, recover evidence, or save belongings before the vessel sinks. Caster, Mover, Apothecary, Hunter, and Deceiver should all have creative opportunities without any one archetype being required.

SCENE 3 - PIECING TOGETHER THE ATTACK

GM LESSON IMPORTANT INFORMATION BELONGS TO THE SCENE Do not lock essential information behind one NPC, object, or check. Hiff, Bell, Jraskor, Jan, physical evidence, tracking, or medical examination can all carry overlapping facts when they make sense. Checks determine quality, cost, position, or extra advantage - not whether the campaign is allowed to continue.

Attackers appeared to be Shanderonian soldiers.

The attack happened recently; the attackers are not far away.

Lantyre Blent is missing from the dead and was alive when the attackers left.

Two crates of Geld were deliberately taken and belong to Hiff Wester.

Hiff transported the Geld alongside his rug business; his rugs were destroyed when the ship flooded.

Hiff's business partner was killed.

The vessel was damaged badly enough that it could not travel much farther.

The attackers left believing everyone aboard was dead or unable to interfere.

Jan survived because he was mistaken for a corpse.

Bell and Jraskor survived by hiding below deck.

Additional direction, number, and condition clues can be placed wherever reasonable, but there should be no Annethil or mercenary reveal yet.

SCENE 4 - THE CALL TO PURSUE

The village does not have a force capable of immediately pursuing trained apparent Shanderonians. Jan is in no condition to chase anyone. The survivors and village need to care for the wounded, dead, and sinking ship and send official word.

The attackers left recently. If Lantyre is alive, this is the window to recover him. Hiff desperately wants his Geld back. The PCs are capable people who just handled the crisis. The scene should naturally turn toward them rather than having someone formally "hire the adventurers."

The request is simple: follow the attackers, rescue Lantyre Blent if possible, and recover Hiff Wester's Geld if possible.

SCENE 5 - FIRST PURSUIT

GM LESSON A PURSUIT IS NOT ONE TRACKING ROLL Treat pursuit as a changing situation. Information can move between clues just as it did on the ship. A Hunter should be especially useful, but a Hunter is never required.

The attackers moved upriver and had another small boat or boats prepared nearby.

They are carrying two heavy Geld crates.

Lantyre is being transported alive.

The PCs can estimate how many attackers remain.

The attackers are moving quickly, but the Geld and prisoner slow them.

Eventually they leave the river and continue on foot.

They appear to know where they are going rather than fleeing randomly.

Suggested pursuit beats include the river trail, a fork/obscured direction, a Level 1-style environmental danger or difficult crossing, and a human trace confirming Lantyre is alive. Failure should cost time, FP, position, Strain, or optional information rather than permanently ending the chase. Critical success can reveal shortcuts, numbers, condition, or grant later advantage.

This is the place to actively remind new players that Tokens are meant to be spent. Session 1 should encourage "I want this to work, so I spend two," not yet "I might need these later."

SCENE 6 - OBVIOUS SAFE REST

The pursuit reaches a small Giljairian river watchhouse or comparable safe shelter. The attackers are close and have stopped for the night. The PCs have enough evidence that the target group is not currently escaping.

GM INSTRUCTION Tell the players clearly that this is a safe opportunity for a Long Rest. Do not make them guess. The point is to teach recovery and let them enter their first combat with full resources. Cautious scouting can reveal enemy count, Lantyre's condition, terrain, or guard positions, but it should not remove the Long Rest opportunity.

SCENE 7 - THE MERCENARY CAMP

The apparent Shanderonian soldiers are camped at an old river landing partly reclaimed by wet forest: a rough clearing, remnants of a dock, a small storage shed, and enough cover to remain hidden from normal river traffic.

Enemy count is exactly one apparent Shanderonian soldier per PC.

All use the same simple soldier template. No lieutenant, caster, or elite is required in the first combat.

Lantyre Blent is alive and restrained near the storage area.

Hiff Wester's two Geld crates are present and ready to be moved.

One soldier is notably concerned with a leather document case, but it should look like ordinary military material at this stage.

Everything continues to support the assumption that these are Shanderonian soldiers.

Ask how the PCs approach. Scouting, distraction, social manipulation, Potezen use, positioning, rescuing Lantyre, and securing the Geld can all change the opening position. Good preparation should matter, but should not bypass the campaign's first combat entirely.

SCENE 8 - FIRST COMBAT

The first battle teaches group turns, Core and Minor Actions, Reactions, positioning, attacks against DA, hit tiers, FP/WP, Tokens, and combat skills. It should be straightforward and last only a few rounds.

The mercenaries are trained people who want to complete a mission and leave, not fanatics who fight to the death.

If the PCs are winning, mercenaries begin withdrawing.

Priorities are escape, the document case, the Geld, and Lantyre - adjusted by what the PCs already secured.

If the PCs are losing, the mercenaries continue their withdrawal rather than stopping to execute them.

If they still control Lantyre or the Geld, they take them. The PCs decide whether to keep fighting, retreat, or let them go.

SCENE 9 - OUTCOME AND COMPLICATION

OUTCOME	RESULT
Failure	Mercenaries escape with Lantyre, Hiff's Geld, and the document case.
Success	The PCs rescue Lantyre; the mercenaries escape with the Geld and document case.
Thorough / Extreme Success	The PCs rescue Lantyre and recover both Geld crates. One soldier still gets away with the document case.

The escaped soldier carries plans related to infiltrating Giljair Keep. Lantyre overheard enough during captivity to know the escaped person had information about the Keep, entry, or getting people inside. At

this point the reasonable interpretation is a Shanderonian military infiltration plan against Giljair's major military stronghold.

Session 1 ends with immediate urgency: someone with Giljair Keep plans is getting away. There is no level-up and no rest before Session 2 begins.

N 6. SESSION 2 - MANAGE

Session 2 begins on the same pursuit, with the characters carrying the exact resource consequences of Session 1. Its first half is about managing scarcity; its second half is about using fresh Level 2 tools against stronger enemies.

SCENE 1 - NO TIME TO REST

At least one apparent Shanderonian has escaped with information concerning the infiltration of Giljair Keep. Depending on Session 1, the fugitives may also still possess Hiff Wester's Geld, Lantyre Blent, or both. The Keep plans alone justify immediate pursuit.

The PCs remain Level 1 and begin with whatever FP, WP, Tokens, and other resources remain after their first battle.

SCENE 2 - RIVER CHASE

The fugitives take a small river vessel. The PCs quickly acquire transportation through the village, the landing, Lantyre if rescued, or another reasonable solution.

The enemy boat is ahead but reachable.

The attackers are pushing their vessel harder than is safe.

Weight slows them, especially if they still have the Geld.

They know enough to follow the river but do not move like people deeply familiar with this stretch of Giljair.

River debris, shallows, dangerous turns, and choices between speed and safety create resource decisions.

Failure costs distance, FP, boat condition, or information rather than ending the chase.

SCENE 3 - THE WRECK

The fleeing boat eventually crashes, grounds, or fails after being pushed too hard. It is pulled partly onto the riverbank and abandoned. The apparent Shanderonians have continued inland.

If they still have Hiff's Geld, evidence shows it was carried onward.

If Lantyre remains captive, evidence shows he was taken inland alive.

The PCs can determine time since departure, direction, number, wounds, and attempts to obscure the trail. Thorough searching gives more information but costs time. Time becomes another resource to manage.

SCENE 4 - OVERLAND HUNT

The chase moves away from the river into wet, green, isolated Giljairian terrain. Use disturbed vegetation, false trails, unstable ground, water crossings, locals, shortcuts, and signs of recent passage. The Hunter should shine but is not required.

At least one decision should make spending 2-3 Tokens very attractive without making failure campaign-ending. The intended question is now: "Do I really need to guarantee this?"

SCENE 5 - THE TRAIL GOES COLD

The fugitives deliberately use converging routes or difficult terrain to lose the party. This is not the result of one failed check; it is a story beat. The PCs know the fugitives are nearby but cannot immediately determine the direction. A town lies ahead.

SCENE 6 - THE TOWN: PLUG-AND-PLAY NPCs

The town name is not locked. This scene teaches a flexible-GM tool: there are more useful locations than named NPCs. The GM places the NPCs wherever the players reasonably choose to engage rather than forcing the players to guess the "correct" building.

Potential locations:

- ◆ Inn / boarding house
- ◆ General store
- ◆ Riverside market
- ◆ Stable / freight yard
- ◆ Newspaper office or seller
- ◆ Small military / service office

NPC	CHARACTER / USE
Mae Gant	Older, practical, knows who passes through town, difficult to impress.
Cal Rainer	Former Infantry soldier now in civilian life; lost friends in the war and has complicated opinions about leadership.
June Holt	Younger local approaching her age-24 obligation and deciding which legal path she will take.

NPC	CHARACTER / USE
Oren Pike	Traveling newspaperman or local correspondent who collects stories aggressively and understands the danger of criticizing power without legal speech protection.

GM LESSON PUT PEOPLE WHERE THE PLAYERS GO If the PCs go to the stable, Cal may work there. If they go to the inn, he may be eating there. Mae can run a stall or be at breakfast. Oren may have an office or simply be carrying papers around town. Locations create possibilities; NPCs create interactions.

Information belongs to the town scene rather than a particular NPC: armed Shanderonians passed nearby; they avoided attention; bought or stole supplies; moved inland; may have communicated with someone; their direction; visible injuries; and any signs of Lantyre/Geld if still captured. The town also introduces normal Giljairian commerce in Geld, private news, military-service culture, fishing/river trade, and ordinary people living under the war.

SCENE 7 - LEVEL 2 MILESTONE

If the PCs rest in town, they take the Long Rest and level normally. If they refuse to rest, they still advance to Level 2 and refresh resources as though rested. The design intentionally guarantees a fresh Level 2 party for the second half of the session.

SCENE 8 - RENEWED PURSUIT

The renewed chase is shorter and partly celebratory. Players have new Level 2 tools and full resources. Situations should invite those tools without becoming lock-and-key puzzles.

The mercenaries now know they are being followed. Their movement becomes controlled; tracks may become suspiciously easy; signs appear deliberately placed; the route funnels toward chosen terrain. A strong result can reveal the coming ambush and improve the party's position. Failure means the ambush gains the opening it wanted, not that the party misses the encounter.

SCENE 9 - THE AMBUSH

The final mercenary force is a clear difficulty jump: approximately Level 3-equivalent enemies fighting Level 2 PCs. Enemy count remains around one enemy per PC, but roughly half the group is Potezen.

PCs	CONVENTIONAL MERCENARIES	POTEZEN MERCENARIES
1	0	1
2	1	1

PCs	CONVENTIONAL MERCENARIES	POTEZEN MERCENARIES
3	1	2
4	2	2
5	2	3
6	3	3

Potezen mercenaries should have clear, compact identities rather than full PC sheets. Caster, Mover, and Deceiver are natural examples. This concentration of capable Potezen signals that someone is deliberately paying for rare talent.

The mercenaries are more coordinated, more committed, and less interested in fleeing than Session 1 enemies. They still do not default to executing defeated PCs. If they win, they can incapacitate, restrain, recover evidence, and leave. Session 3 is where lethal protection comes off.

SCENE 10 - THE ANNETHIL REVEAL

The Annethil connection must survive different outcomes. If the PCs capture or defeat the mercenaries, a survivor can express that they would rather die than return after failing Annethil. If mercenaries flee, a note, order, payment record, or partial correspondence is left behind. If the PCs lose, evidence can still remain in the aftermath.

The reveal should establish that Annethil hired or directed these mercenaries, the Navy attacks are part of something larger, Giljair Keep is a future objective, and other groups are involved. It should not yet reveal every detail of the assassination plan.

SCENE 11 - SESSION 2 ENDING

The party now understands that the attackers were Shanderonian mercenaries rather than regular Shanderonian troops, and that one of Giljair's Nine Families is paying foreign mercenaries to attack Giljairian military assets. Giljair Keep is central to whatever comes next.

Unlike Session 1, the ending is not "run, they are getting away." It is a decision point: what do the PCs do with this information? After the session, advance them to Level 3 and refresh them fully before Session 3 begins.

7. SESSION 3 - ENDURE / DECIDE

OPENING RESOURCE STATE: ONE POOL FOR THE ENTIRE SESSION

The PCs begin Session 3 at Level 3 and fully rested. From that moment onward, there are no Short Rests or Long Rests for the rest of the campaign - not during the discovery phase, not before sundown, and not during the invasion.

Every Token, FP loss, skill use, consumable, or other limited resource spent while investigating Annethil, entering the Keep, persuading NPCs, sabotaging alarms, or preparing remains spent when the fighting begins. Arriving early gives more opportunities, not more recovery.

OPENING DISCOVERY / ROLEPLAY

The PCs travel to a town close enough to Giljair's centers of power that information about The Citadel, Giljair Keep, Annethil, and Hiff Bagimoos circulates. The town name and fixed cast are not separately locked; it is an information-and-perspective scene. A captured Session 2 mercenary, if the PCs kept one alive, is a meaningful reward and can confirm pieces of the conspiracy, but does not replace the roleplay/investigation section.

The party needs to assemble these larger truths through interaction and discovery:

It is the Year of Annethil, and Annethil currently serves as Head of the Nine and Peasant Judge.

Tension has grown between Annethil and Hiff Bagimoos.

Hiff's influence has grown because of the long war.

Some people genuinely believe Hiff now has more practical power than the Nine.

Concern about this imbalance exists across the Nine, not only within Annethil.

Annethil is the House that decided to take direct action.

Recent attacks have caused military assets to redeploy away from Giljair Keep.

Those movements have weakened the Keep.

Additional mercenary groups have been hired.

Giljair Keep is the culmination of the plan.

The ultimate target is Hiff Bagimoos.

Annethil intends to kill Hiff and break/rebalance the military's current political power.

GM LESSON SEPARATE FACTS FROM OPINIONS NPCs do not need to lie for there to be disagreement. Let several people know different parts of the truth and interpret the same facts differently. A retired soldier can argue Hiff is why Giljair survives; a news writer can agree his power is dangerous while condemning Annethil's methods; someone tied to Annethil can understand the fear of military rule; a family member with someone serving may care most that soldiers are dying because of political maneuvering. The players assemble the situation and decide what it means.

EARLIER CHOICES RETURN

EARLIER CHOICE / OUTCOME	POSSIBLE SESSION 3 BENEFIT OR CONSEQUENCE
Lantyre Blent rescued	A Crew Officer can vouch for the PCs and substantially improve legitimate access to Giljair Keep.
Jan Ian Tor saved	A living Amphibious crewman can corroborate the original attack and provide military credibility.
Hiff Wester's Geld recovered	Hiff Wester has money, merchant connections, and a reason to help.
Hiff Wester's Geld not recovered	Some of that Geld may become traceable into Annethil's mercenary payments.
Mercenary kept alive	A credible witness can confirm Annethil's payments and the mercenary structure.
Mercenaries spared / relationships preserved	Survivors may become information sources or situational allies.
Evidence preserved	Documents may substitute for witnesses when presenting the case to officers or representatives.

THE PLAYERS CHOOSE THE OBJECTIVE

Everyone ends up at Giljair Keep. The branching question is not where the adventure goes, but what the PCs intend to accomplish once they are there.

Help Annethil weaken the Keep or kill Hiff Bagimoos.

Warn and protect Hiff.

Capture or trap Hiff without simply empowering Annethil.

Expose Annethil to the Nine or public.

Try to stop both sides or force a confrontation.

Use the invasion as cover to steal military intelligence, Geld, equipment, or something else.

Free prisoners or rescue a particular person.

Invent another objective the adventure did not anticipate.

PREPARE THE SITUATION, NOT BRANCHES The GM does not need a separate adventure for every possible objective. Know what Annethil wants, what Hiff wants, what defenders want, what mercenaries want, and what important NPCs want. Then respond to the players' choices.

N 8. GILJAIR KEEP - ENTRY AND THEATER-OF-THE-MIND STRUCTURE

NO CANONICAL KEEP MAP

Giljair Keep intentionally does not need a fixed dungeon map. This is a GM lesson in constructing a theater-of-the-mind complex during play.

The GM has four major locations, a central Tower, multiple entrances, Hallways, and Courtyards/Open Areas.

The GM decides what is next to what and guides movement through description.

Once a connection is established, keep it consistent. If the Barracks is said to open into an eastern courtyard, that remains true for this version of the Keep.

The four important areas are not everything that exists. The GM should invent ordinary military spaces, roofs, kitchens, yards, storage, stables, smoke, laundry, repairs, and other details that make the Keep feel occupied.

MINI-ROOMS: HALLWAYS AND COURTYARDS

Hallways and courtyards/open areas are transitional "mini-rooms." They are places where the PCs may briefly exist between major locations and where fighting, wounded people, fleeing soldiers, barricades, conversations, or momentary calm can occur.

Hallways are enclosed and easier to block or avoid. Courtyards expose the PCs to multiple directions, towers, ranged threats, and groups moving between buildings.

FOUR PRIMARY ENTRY APPROACHES

ENTRY	PRIMARY CHALLENGE	MAIN COST / RISK	MAJOR BENEFIT
River Entrance	Stealth plus physical danger	FP/resources; drowning or forced retreat at a locked barred gate	Nobody knows the PCs are inside if they succeed.
Main Gate	Diplomacy, proof, reputation	Reveals presence and possibly intent	Legitimate access; easier social movement inside.
Over the Walls	Preparation and planning	Time; invasion begins quickly after entry	Control where/how the party enters.
Hidden Through Main Gate	Stealth/deception while concealed in cart, cargo, hay, disguises, etc.	Discovery may lead to arrest, pursuit, split party, or combat	Quiet entry without the river's physical danger.

RIVER ENTRANCE

Part of the river or diverted waterway passes through the city and beneath/through a portion of Giljair Keep. The route was not designed for people. Strong current, debris, narrow/submerged passages, and breath limits make the path itself dangerous even without guards.

At the end is a locked, barred interior gate. Before the invasion, the PCs must solve it to get through: picking the locks, forcing the mechanism, using Potezen abilities, or convincing or bribing someone inside to open it, all while the current and their breath work against them. If they cannot, they retreat before they drown. At sundown the gate is opened from the inside for the invading mercenaries anyway, turning the same route into an invasion access point, so a party that waits can slip in with the attack rather than solve the gate themselves.

MAIN GATE

The main gate is the diplomatic route. Lantyre Blent can substantially improve credibility if rescued, though he cannot grant unlimited access. Evidence, a living mercenary, proof of attacks, Annethil documents, bribery, bluffing, or other social approaches can all matter. Success means the PCs are inside legitimately, but their presence is known.

OVER THE WALLS

This route rewards preparation: rope, climbing gear, patrol information, distractions, Potezen powers, and other planning can make the actual climb easier. The tradeoff is time. By the time a party enters this way, sundown should be close and the attack begins soon after they get inside.

HIDDEN THROUGH THE MAIN GATE

The PCs move through the normal gate without being recognized as entrants: hidden under hay, inside cargo, among laborers, beneath a wagon, or through another player-created concealment. Discovery does not end the campaign. Arrest may simply deliver them, under guard, into the War Room, where Blanden is working before the attack, turning a failed entry into an immediate roleplay confrontation rather than a dead end.

GM LESSON **LIKELY SOLUTIONS ARE NOT A MENU** Do not present four buttons to the players. Present the problem: "You need to get inside Giljair Keep. How are you doing it?" These are likely approaches the GM can support. If the players invent a fifth, use it.

9. GILJAIR KEEP - FOUR MAJOR AREAS

These four areas are intentionally more fixed than the earlier town. Certain NPCs, information, items, and opportunities belong in specific places. This teaches the GM when consistency and location specificity matter.

AREA 1 - BARRACKS & MESS

LAYOUT

A central mess hall contains several long tables and a kitchen-like area at the back. Three hallways form a U-shape around the mess hall. Each hallway contains six rooms, three on each side, for a total of 18 sleeping rooms.

SOLDIERS

The GM can manually place Giljairian soldiers in any of the 18 rooms, choose a number based on desired difficulty, or use a quick optional roll such as 1d12 to decide how many are present. Before the attack, soldiers found in these rooms are probably sleeping or resting.

Barracks personnel are plug-and-play: each soldier may use Fodder Fighter, Standard Fighter, or Elite Fighter depending on the desired difficulty. Their in-world rank does not force a combat tier.

THE "TRAP"

There are no designed traps here. The danger is opening the wrong door and finding sleeping Giljairian soldiers. Whether they become allies, witnesses, or enemies depends on how the PCs entered and what they are doing.

STAN, THE COOK

Stan is the fixed NPC for this area. Before the invasion, he is the person most reliably awake and has heard years of soldiers' conversations. He can describe both deep loyalty to Hiff Bagimoos and unease about how personally loyal some soldiers have become.

INFORMATION AND PERSPECTIVE

Some soldiers credit Hiff with keeping Giljair from losing the war or saving particular units.

Some believe the Nine argue safely while Hiff understands what combat requires.

Some would follow him nearly blindly and treat a personal order from him as enough justification.

Others worry that officers increasingly speak about loyalty to Hiff personally rather than loyalty to Giljair.

Some believe the army is beginning to feel like "his" army.

A soldier can believe Hiff has too much power and still regard Annethil's use of foreign mercenaries as treason.

ROOMS / PERSONAL EFFECTS

Letters from spouses, parents, or children

Uniforms and weapons near beds

Small amounts of Geld

Keepsakes and news sheets

Duty schedules or informal notes

Evidence of dead friends, unused bunks, or possessions being held for family

Most of this is context rather than valuable loot. If PCs steal from sleeping soldiers, they are choosing to steal from identifiable people rather than faceless treasure containers.

AFTER SUNDOWN

Every soldier in the area wakes and arms themselves. Stan becomes ready to fight as well. The number established before the attack remains the number of active soldiers now. Their relationship to the PCs depends on earlier trust, entry method, theft, deception, and the PCs' chosen side.

AREA 2 - THE CENTRAL TOWER

Giljair Keep has a single watchtower standing at its center, tall enough to see the whole complex. Its purpose is protection and observation, not general communications.

ALARM NETWORK

The Tower has a central alarm bell.

There is one additional ground-level alarm post inside the Keep. Its exact theater-of-the-mind placement is GM-chosen.

There are therefore two locations capable of raising a Keep-wide alarm: the Tower bell and the ground post.

In theory, the PCs can disable both. If every alarm is disabled, the Keep receives no unified alarm when the invasion begins; sections react only when they directly see or hear fighting or receive runners. The Tower bell is obvious; the ground post is not something to hide behind a search check. The moment the players set out to silence the Keep's alarms, introduce the ground post in the next hallway or courtyard as the natural second target they will also need to handle. Surfacing it through play, rather than burying it, is itself the lesson: a required step belongs to the scene, not to a die roll the party might never think to make.

TOWER PERSONNEL

The Tower is staffed by an Infantry unit specialized in bowmen and led by a Command. The Tower Command and its soldiers are plug-and-play combat bodies: the GM may use Fodder Fighter, Standard Fighter, or Elite Fighter for any of them depending on the desired difficulty.

At any given time, 3 Infantry are actively on the watchtower.

At most 4 additional Infantry are sleeping/resting below.

They work roughly 12-hour rotating shifts, one shift per day.

The Command often overlaps the two shifts rather than following one strict watch schedule.

The GM may choose the number actively available based on desired difficulty rather than altering enemy statistics.

DISABLING A BELL

Players might cut/remove a rope, jam the clapper, damage the mechanism, use Potezen abilities, trick the guards, or otherwise sabotage the bell. Disabling it does not automatically alert the soldiers; being caught doing so probably does. A hostile Tower is also an elevated bow position, so neutralizing one can matter beyond the alarm itself.

THE VIEW

The Tower is a GM tool for describing Giljair Keep from above: walls, the river, the main gate, the barracks, the Wing of the Nine, the War Room, protected military sections, roads, smoke, boats, soldiers, and surrounding terrain. Add details freely, then keep established connections consistent.

AFTER SUNDOWN

If the bell works and the watch recognizes the attack, it rings. Resting soldiers wake. Bowmen focus on identifying attackers, firing from elevation, protecting the bell, and watching approaches. If the bell was disabled, the unit must shout, send a runner, reach another alarm, or simply join the defense. If the PCs are atop a Tower when the invasion begins, they can watch the coup unfold across the Keep before choosing where to go.

AREA 3 - WAR ROOM

The War Room is an immediate decision/conflict space rather than an investigation room. Its centerpiece is a Living Table.

LIVING TABLE

A Living Table is a live, active three-dimensional map. Its effect may look holographic at a glance, but the table itself physically moves and rebuilds its surface to present what is happening in the monitored area. A Binder and Builder create a monitored section together so events can be observed from a distance. Giljair Keep is already covered by such a zone. Remote battlefields require Table Viewing Stones placed on location; those can be obstructed.

BEFORE THE ATTACK

Hiff Bagimoos is not here. Blanden, a Superior and Mover, is present and working. Entering the room creates an immediate roleplay confrontation: Why are the PCs here, and what do they want? If the players attack, it can become combat, but the room is not designed around searching drawers for answers.

Blanden knows the Keep is stretched thin, recent attacks have caused unusual redeployments, Hiff suspects something larger, and security is tightening. Blanden does not automatically know the Annethil conspiracy.

AFTER THE ATTACK

Hiff Bagimoos can reliably be found here once the invasion begins. The Living Table actively shows the battle developing: fights at different sections, soldiers moving, alarms or suspicious silence, attackers at the river or gates, and sectors that have not yet reacted.

This is likely one of the campaign's most important roleplay scenes. The PCs may warn Hiff, protect him, accuse him, demand surrender, trap him, assassinate him, manipulate his orders, or help attackers reach him. Combat is possible, but not assumed.

If the PCs gain control of the War Room or persuade Hiff to cooperate, the Living Table becomes a strategic tool for choosing routes, identifying crises, locating fighting, and seeing the consequences of earlier alarm sabotage.

CINEMATIC RHYTHM During the invasion, combat and roleplay may repeatedly interrupt each other. A fight can stop because someone talks, surrenders, or reveals something. A conversation can become violent when an alarm rings or a weapon is drawn. Every area is a situation, not a predetermined encounter type.

AREA 5 - WING OF THE NINE

The Wing of the Nine is a political compound, not a small room. A very large council chamber sits at the center, and nine named hallways lead off it to the individual Houses' private suites, each House's name displayed above its entrance. For this campaign the playable focus is the Annethil section; the other eight are set dressing unless the players force their way into one.

FAMILY GUARD

Each House representative has a specialized Family Guard of 2-3 guards. These are not ordinary Giljairian soldiers; they serve their House directly. Before the attack, one Family Guard stands at each House hallway entrance while the remaining guards stay deeper in that House's section.

Although the Wing may contain 18-27 Family Guards in total if all representatives are present, they are not standing together waiting to fight the PCs. The PCs would have to deliberately escalate or attack into the House sections to turn the entire compound into a massive battle.

REPRESENTATIVES

The one representative who matters here is Roderi Gamb, "Here for the House of Annethil." Any other House is present only in the abstract: if the players insist on approaching one, a representative speaks "for the House of [House Name]," but a representative does not automatically know every secret or crime committed by their House leadership, and none of the other eight is materially involved in the plot.

Roderi Gamb is materially involved in the plot and may be pursued, cornered, fought, captured, or killed.

BEFORE THE ATTACK

This should be a roleplay scene. The PCs may seek the Annethil representative, present evidence, ask for authority, or seek support. Family Guards ask why their representative should see the PCs. Lantyre can establish credibility but does not automatically grant political access.

If the PCs intentionally start a fight, this is extremely dangerous. Other guards react, representatives retreat, and deeper Family Guards emerge. The campaign should not artificially protect PCs who choose to attack the private guards of Giljair's rulers.

AFTER SUNDOWN

The entrance guards disappear from the central hall because each Family Guard falls back to protect its representative. Eight House residential sections lock down. The PCs must convince occupants to open, force entry, or leave them alone.

The Annethil section is different: it is open and abandoned. Roderi Gamb and Annethil's Family Guards intentionally left before the invasion so they would not be trapped inside their own House's operation. The open hallway among eight locked sections is itself information.

Inside the Annethil residence, the PCs may find planned-departure signs, missing personal property, discarded papers, and confirmation that Roderi knew something was coming. Earlier relationships with other Houses can determine whether they open their doors and contribute Family Guards to the defense or another plan.

10. RUNNING THE SUNDOWN INVASION

THE INVASION HAPPENS NO MATTER WHAT

Annethil's invasion begins at sundown regardless of the PCs' choices. The players can change preparation, allies, alarms, access, and outcomes. They cannot prevent the attempt from beginning.

HOW EARLY DO THE PCS ARRIVE?

The GM judges arrival time from how quickly or slowly the PCs acted across the campaign and Session 3 lead-up. Very efficient PCs may have enough time to explore every major area, including the Tower. PCs who delay may arrive as the attack begins or after it is underway.

DEFAULT TIMING RULE If it is not clear how much pre-sundown time the party earned, allow them to meaningfully explore three important locations. When they move toward the fourth, sundown arrives and the invasion begins. The Tower counts when meaningfully explored; Hallways and Courtyards normally do not. Even an early arrival does not create enough downtime for a Short Rest.

STAGE 1 - ATTACK BEGINS

This stage covers the first two major locations meaningfully explored after sundown. Fighting has started, but the Keep is not fully organized around the crisis. Bells may ring, people shout orders, isolated fights begin, and some halls remain relatively clear. This is the easiest post-sundown window to pursue the party's primary objective.

STAGE 2 - KEEP BECOMES CONTESTED

After two post-sundown locations, the battle escalates. During the next two major locations, combatants move throughout the Keep. Giljairian soldiers, mercenaries, Family Guards, wounded fighters, messengers, and others appear in Hallways and Courtyards. Travel is risky but does not automatically mean combat; the PCs may pass, negotiate, hide, intervene, or exploit other fights.

STAGE 3 - BATTLE AT ITS WORST

After two more major locations, the Keep reaches its worst point. Leaving rooms is dangerous. Opposing soldiers are everywhere. Unless earlier actions clearly prevent it, at least one or two opposing combatants should generally be present in each area, though they may be fighting someone else, searching, guarding, retreating, or otherwise occupied rather than immediately attacking the PCs.

If the PCs have not accomplished their goal yet, doing so is now harder. Whether or not they succeed, the final priority becomes survival and getting out of Giljair Keep.

Difficulty rises through attrition and worsening circumstances, not by secretly inflating enemy numbers or statistics. The party has fewer resources while routes become blocked, defenders and attackers organize, Potezen enter the fighting, and every move becomes more dangerous.

OPTIONAL TRANSITIONAL ENCOUNTER TABLE

D6	HALLWAY / COURTYARD SITUATION
1	The route is temporarily clear, but fighting can be heard nearby.
2	A wounded or frightened combatant is trying to reach safety and may know something useful.
3	A small group moves through the area without initially knowing which side the PCs support.
4	Two opposing groups are already confronting or fighting each other. The PCs choose whether to intervene.
5	The route is blocked, barricaded, damaged, or watched. Another solution is needed.

D6	HALLWAY / COURTYARD SITUATION
6	Bring back an ally, officer, mercenary, escaped prisoner, Family Guard, or other NPC relevant to the current situation.

RODERI GAMB AND THE NINE

Roderi has been one of the main people gathering and feeding information about Hiff's growing influence upward. Most of that work serves Annethil leadership, but concern about Hiff exists across the heads of the Nine. Roderi knows the full Annethil plan; the other Houses do not automatically know or approve of the assault.

THE NINE SHARE A PROBLEM, NOT A SOLUTION Most or all of the Families are concerned about the Lead Superior's growing power. Only Annethil has chosen to resolve that concern through foreign mercenaries, attacks on Giljairian military assets, and an assault intended to kill Hiff Bagimoos.

11. NPC ROSTER

Individual NPC entries include only the information needed to run the campaign. Generic combat references already contain DA, FP, WP, and basic attack values. Unique NPCs are summarized here and fully detailed in Section 12.

1. JESTINE LYN

Role: Dockmaster and primary local NPC at Cypress Bend Location: Cypress Bend docks Combat Reference: Fodder Fighter

Purpose / Information: Rings the morning dock bell and serves breakfast, naturally bringing the PCs together. Can introduce ordinary Giljairian life: fishing, Navy traffic, Geld, military-service culture, private news, and the normalcy of war. Recognizes that something is wrong when the damaged vessel appears.

2. JAN IAN TOR

Role: Amphibious crewman and survivor of the Navy attack Location: Damaged Navy vessel Combat Reference: Standard Fighter

Purpose / Information: The only surviving military person aboard. Was struck repeatedly and left for dead. Can corroborate that the attackers appeared Shanderonian, that the attack was recent, and that Lantyre is missing. If saved, can later provide military credibility.

3. HIFF WESTER

Role: Rug merchant and survivor Location: Damaged Navy vessel Combat Reference: Basic NPC

Purpose / Information: His business partner was killed, rugs destroyed, and two crates of Geld stolen. Wants the Geld recovered. If the PCs recover it, he later has money and merchant connections that can help; if not, some stolen Geld may be traceable into Annethil's mercenary payments.

4. BELL RUSK

Role: Civilian passenger and survivor Location: Damaged Navy vessel Combat Reference: Basic NPC

Purpose / Information: Traveling with Jraskor to visit their children. Survived by hiding below deck. Can provide reasonable overlapping eyewitness information from the attack; no essential clue should belong only to Bell.

5. JRASKOR RUSK

Role: Civilian passenger and survivor Location: Damaged Navy vessel Combat Reference: Basic NPC

Purpose / Information: Traveling with Bell to visit their children. Survived below deck. Can provide reasonable overlapping eyewitness information from the attack; no essential clue should belong only to Jraskor.

6. LANTYRE BLENT

Role: Crew Officer and highest-ranking officer aboard the attacked vessel Location: Initially held captive by the mercenaries Combat Reference: Elite Fighter

Purpose / Information: Was deliberately taken alive. Overheard enough to know an attacker carried information about Giljair Keep, entry, or getting people inside. If rescued, can vouch for the PCs and significantly improve legitimate Keep access.

Special Note: When first recovered, Lantyre begins at 0 FP / 1 WP because of the kidnapping and treatment.

7. MAE GANT

Role: Older local who pays attention to who passes through town Combat Reference: Basic NPC

Purpose / Information: Modular Session 2 town NPC. Can carry any reasonable pursuit clue that belongs to the town scene: unusual armed travelers, supplies, direction, injuries, or signs of Lantyre/Geld.

8. CAL RAINER

Role: Former Giljairian Infantry soldier now living as a civilian Combat Reference: Standard Fighter

Purpose / Information: Modular Session 2 town NPC. Can carry pursuit clues and expose ordinary military experience: lost friends, long-war weariness, and complicated opinions about leadership.

II. STAN

Role: Barracks cook Location: Barracks & Mess Combat Reference: Fodder Fighter

Purpose / Information: Usually the most reliably awake person before sundown. Has heard years of soldier conversation and can describe both strong loyalty to Hiff and unease about personal loyalty replacing loyalty to Giljair. Arms himself during the invasion.

12. TOWER COMMAND

Role: Command overseeing the central watchtower unit Location: The Central Tower Combat Reference: GM chooses Fodder / Standard / Elite

Purpose / Information: No name required. Runs the watch personnel and protects the alarm network. Rank does not dictate combat tier.

TOWER SOLDIERS

Role: Infantry soldiers assigned to the tower watch Location: The Central Tower Combat Reference: GM chooses Fodder / Standard / Elite

Purpose / Information: Plug-and-play personnel. Watch approaches, protect bells, use ranged fire from elevation, and send runners or respond directly if alarms are disabled.

BARRACKS SOLDIERS

Role: Giljairian military personnel resting in the Barracks Location: Barracks & Mess Combat Reference: GM chooses Fodder / Standard / Elite

Purpose / Information: Plug-and-play personnel. Their number and capability are GM-tunable. Their attitude toward the PCs depends on entry method, trust, theft, deception, and chosen side.

13. BLANDEN

Role: Superior; pre-invasion War Room advisor Location: War Room Combat Reference: Unique - Mover

Purpose / Information: Knows the Keep is stretched thin, recent attacks caused unusual redeployments, Hiff suspects something larger, and security is tightening. Does not automatically know the Annethil conspiracy.

14. RODERI GAMB

Role: "Here for the House of Annethil" Location: Wing of the Nine before the invasion Combat Reference: Basic NPC

Purpose / Information: Serves as Annethil's representative and has been one of the primary people gathering information about Hiff's increasing influence. Concern about Hiff is shared among House leadership across the Nine.

Secret: Knows the full Annethil plan: the military-depletion attacks, the Keep assault at sundown, and Hiff Bagimoos as the ultimate target. Deliberately leaves before the invasion with Annethil's Family Guards.

15. HIFF BAGIMOOS

Role: Lead Superior of Giljair; member of House Bagimoos Location: War Room after the invasion begins
Combat Reference: Unique - Deceiver

Purpose / Information: Did not seek personal rule, but refuses to let Giljair lose because of oligarchic paralysis. His practical authority and the army's increasing personal loyalty to him are the political problem at the center of the campaign. The PCs may protect, accuse, capture, manipulate, or kill him.

Secret: Believes the Keep is merely stretched thin by redeployments, not that a coup is closing on him personally.

16. CONTIER DORN

Role: Mercenary field leader of Annethil's assault Location: Moves with Annethil's assault forces Combat Reference: Unique - Hunter

Purpose / Information: Highly paid mercenary hired to execute the operation. Understands the operational information needed to lead the assault but is not an ideological participant in Annethil's political struggle. Can be opposed, assisted, captured, killed, or potentially bargained with.



12. UNIQUE NPC COMBAT PROFILES

UNIQUE NPC FORMAT Unique NPCs still do not use Tokens. Their listed attacks use baked-in modifiers. Player-like skills have fixed uses unless the entry explicitly says unlimited. Generic hit severity applies unless a special action says otherwise.

BLANDEN - SUPERIOR / MOVER

DA 11 | FP 15 | WP 8

Ball Bearings - Core: 1d12 +4 vs. target DA, Close/Far. Blanden carries pea-sized metal ball bearings in a bag and launches them telekinetically. Uses standard hit severity.

Kinetic Surge - Minor, 3 uses: 1d12 +4 vs. DA 8. On success, Blanden's next attack increases by one damage tier.

Mind Shield - Minor, 4 uses: Use +4 for the activation check and subsequent concentration checks. One use is spent when the shield is activated; maintaining an already-active shield does not consume another use. Resolve the protective effect as the Level 2 Mover skill. DA 11 is deliberate: rather than tracking a separate dodge move each round, Blanden's Mover reflexes are folded into a raised DA so combat flows. Unlike Hiff Bagimoos, whose techniques have unlimited uses, Blanden's abilities are limited-use, and the higher DA stands in for the evasive movement those Mover skills would otherwise represent.

HIFF BAGIMOOS - LEAD SUPERIOR / DECEIVER

DA 9 | FP 24 | WP 20

Sword - Core: 1d12 +6 vs. target DA, Close. Uses standard hit severity. The +6 reflects Hiff's exceptional STR.

Deceiver Checks: Use +4 for every check required by Hiff's Deceiver skills.

Deceiver Techniques - Unlimited: For this mini-campaign, Hiff has access to every Deceiver skill through Level 3 and does not track uses or Tokens. Use the normal Level 1-3 player-skill effects.

Relevant Deceiver skill list: Sensory Whisper; Planted Seed; Static; False Opening; Hollow Face; Read the Room; Sensory Flicker; The Drop; Hollow Threat; Shadow Step; The Unseen Hand; Convincing Exit; The Badge; Still Waters.

Passive skills such as Read the Room and Still Waters function normally. Hiff also has significant defensive equipment, but only equipment that becomes mechanically relevant needs to be added at the table.

CONTIER DORN - MERCENARY ASSAULT LEADER / HUNTER

DA 9 | FP 18 | WP 14

Bow - Core: 1d12 +4 vs. target DA, Close/Far/In the Distance. Uses standard hit severity.

Arrow as Knife - Core: 1d12 +2 vs. target DA, Close. Contier can use an arrow as a melee weapon rather than switching equipment.

Called Shot - 2 uses: Declare a specific location on a Bow attack. On a hit, apply an appropriate effect supported by what was targeted, following the Hunter skill.

Steady Draw - Unlimited: Before a ranged attack, Contier may take aim. On a hit, increase the resulting damage by one tier.

Long Shot - Unlimited / Passive: Contier's Bow attacks can reach targets In the Distance as well as Close or Far.



13. USING ALLIES AND POWERFUL NPCs

ALLIES CHANGE THE SITUATION

The PCs are not the entire army. They may earn soldiers, Family Guards, officers, Lantyre, or other people who can influence the invasion. Do not simulate large NPC-vs-NPC battles unless the PCs are directly involved and the outcome truly matters.

ALLY CONTRIBUTION	EXAMPLE EFFECT
Handle a threat	An allied group resolves a fight the PCs otherwise would have faced.
Reduce a threat	Allies occupy several enemies; the PCs only deal with the remainder.

ALLY CONTRIBUTION	EXAMPLE EFFECT
Hold a route	A Hallway or Courtyard becomes temporarily safe.
Secure a location	A major area remains under friendly control after the PCs leave.
Create a distraction	Enemy attention moves elsewhere, allowing infiltration or escape.
Provide information	Allies report where Hiff, attackers, or other important people were last seen.
Buy time	Allies delay enemies while the PCs complete their objective.
Create a base of operations	Allies hold a defensible room where the party can briefly regroup, talk, rearrange equipment, and plan. This is safety, not a Short Rest.
Help the escape	Allies cover an exit, open a route, escort the PCs, or hold enemies while they leave.

These benefits are primarily at the GM's discretion. Use what the PCs actually earned and what those allies reasonably can do.

N 14. OBJECTIVE RESOLUTION AND AFTERMATH

KNOW WHAT THE PLAYERS ARE TRYING TO DO

Before the invasion reaches its worst stage, the GM should be able to privately finish this sentence: "The players are trying to _____. " The objective can change during play, and the GM should update it when the players clearly change course.

Keep Hiff Bagimoos alive.

Kill Hiff Bagimoos.

Help Annethil seize the Keep.

Capture Hiff before either side controls him.

Expose Annethil.

Steal military intelligence.

Free prisoners and escape.

Make sure neither side fully controls the outcome.

Any other player-created goal.

LET SUCCESS BE SUCCESS When the players actually accomplish what they set out to accomplish, let it count. Do not add a new arbitrary requirement because the adventure expected a different ending. Success can still have ugly consequences.

Once the objective is accomplished - or becomes impossible - the session transitions toward escape. The PCs choose an exit: Main Gate, River Entrance, over the walls, or another route created during play. Allies and prior preparation can make the escape safer. There is no mandatory final boss fight if the party earned a clean way out.

AFTERMATH GUIDANCE

Once the PCs reach safety, stop tracking the Keep minute by minute. Resolve immediate consequences based on what the party changed.

Did Hiff Bagimoos survive?

Did Annethil's plan succeed?

Was Annethil exposed?

Which representatives and Family Guards survived or intervened?

Which parts of Giljair Keep remained under military control?

What did the PCs steal or carry out?

Who now considers the PCs allies, traitors, criminals, heroes, or targets?

Did the PCs themselves escape?

What became publicly known about the attack?

Give each PC or the group one or two immediate closing consequences. The campaign does not need to define the entire future of Giljair. The point is that the players entered a conflict among powerful people, chose what mattered to them, and changed what happened.

15. GM RUNNING PRINCIPLES AND FLEXIBLE ELEMENTS

CORE GM LESSONS THE CAMPAIGN IS TEACHING

Important information belongs to scenes, not single checks or single NPCs.

Failure should change cost, position, time, resources, or information quality rather than dead-ending the campaign.

Pursuits are sequences of changing problems, not one tracking roll.

Useful NPCs can move to where the players actually go when the scene is intentionally modular.

Fixed locations matter when the campaign wants spatial consistency and specific consequences.

Prepare factions, goals, and situations rather than writing branches for every player choice.

NPCs and allies change situations; they do not replace player decisions.

Difficulty should rise through attrition, organization, blocked routes, and worsening circumstances rather than secretly inflating numbers.

Combat does not have to begin or end with violence. Surrender, negotiation, retreat, interruption, and changing sides are all legitimate outcomes.

Once the players accomplish their chosen objective, let it be real.

INTENTIONALLY FLEXIBLE / GM-CHOICE ELEMENTS

The exact map and adjacency of Giljair Keep are not canonical. Once established at a table, connections remain consistent.

Session 2 town name is not locked. Mae Gant and Cal Rainer are modular and can appear at locations the PCs choose.

The Session 3 discovery town name and fixed cast are not locked; the scene is defined by truths and competing perspectives rather than one exposition NPC.

The Tower Command, Tower Soldiers, and Barracks Soldiers are plug-and-play Fodder, Standard, or Elite bodies. Military rank does not dictate combat tier.

The exact placement of the ground-level alarm post is not locked; it should exist as a believable Keep-wide alarm point surfaced when the players go looking to silence the alarms.

Aside from Roderi Gamb, the Houses of the Nine are left undetailed; only Annethil is developed for this campaign.

The exact composition of generic mercenary combat profiles can be tuned to the party while preserving the locked counts, Potezen ratio, and intended difficulty jump.

ENCOUNTER SCALING PHILOSOPHY

Scale primarily by bodies and combat references, not by inflating DA or attack bonuses. Session 1 uses exactly one identical apparent Shanderonian soldier per PC and is intended to be simple. Session 2 uses roughly one enemy per PC, with about half Potezen and an intentional jump toward Level 3-equivalent opposition. Session 3 becomes dangerous because the PCs have one resource pool for the whole session and the Keep becomes progressively more contested.



APPENDIX A. TECHNOLOGY REFERENCE

Giljair, like the rest of Nesloke, runs on magic-enhanced technology rather than machinery. The campaign uses one example directly, the Living Table: a live, three-dimensional map that a Binder and Builder create together over a monitored area, so a commander can watch a battle unfold from a distance. Its surface physically moves and rebuilds itself to show what is happening; the effect can look holographic at a glance. Giljair Keep is already inside such a monitored zone. Remote battlefields need Table Viewing Stones placed on location, and those can be obstructed. Treat it as a window onto the fight, not a control panel.



APPENDIX B. LOCKED NAMES AND NAMING STYLE

LOCKED NAMES

Annethil - current Head of the Nine and coup family.

Sharbeerd - one of the Nine.

Bagimoos, Greval, Newcera, Forjinks, Stealelle, Midclow, Elsver - remaining Families of Power.

Jestine Lyn - Cypress Bend dockmaster.

Jan Ian Tor - Amphibious crewman.

Hiff Wester - rug merchant.

Bell Rusk and Jraskor Rusk - civilian survivors.

Lantyre Blent - Crew Officer.

Mae Gant and Cal Rainer - modular Session 2 town NPCs.

Stan - Barracks cook.

Blanden - Superior and Mover in the War Room.

Roderi Gamb - "Here for the House of Annethil."

Hiff Bagimoos - Lead Superior; member of House Bagimoos.

Contier Dorn - mercenary assault leader.

The Citadel - western political castle.

Giljair Keep - eastern military castle.

INTENTIONALLY UNNAMED / OFFICE-ONLY

The Tower Command and ordinary Tower and Barracks soldiers do not need names.

NAMING STYLE REMINDER

Ordinary people should have ordinary, grounded, occasionally awkward names. Elevated or ancient-sounding names can be reserved for aristocratic families such as Annethil or Ilmarinen. Avoid smooth two-syllable fantasy-generator names that make the setting feel generic.